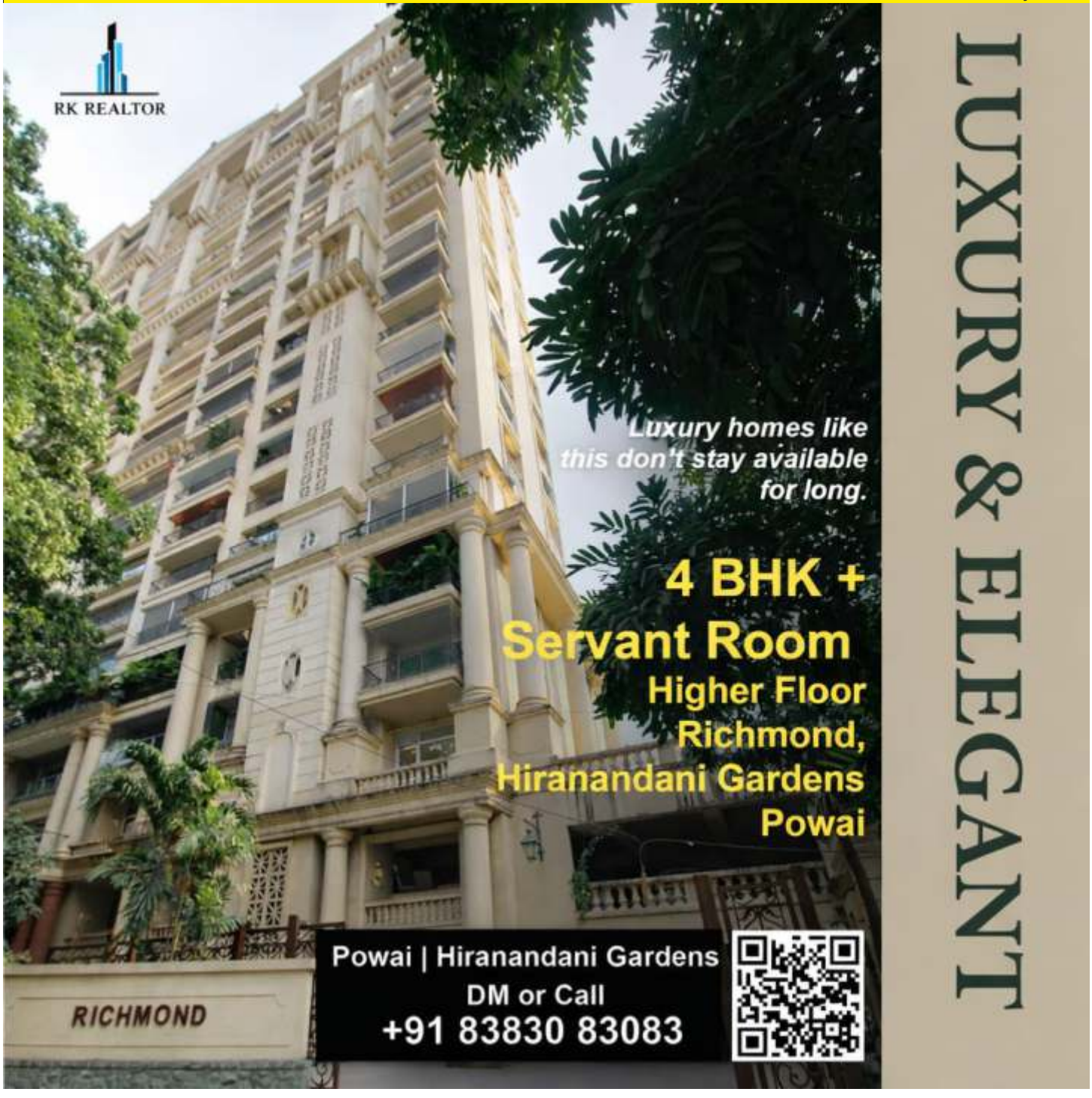
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MY POWAI

Volume No. 14 Issue No. 06 Mumbai February 2026



Dear friends

February settles into Powai with cooler days and a gentle nip in the air—perfect for slowing down and taking note of what's happening around us.

January marked an important chapter for Powai and Chandivali with the election of new corporators. We had brief, candid conversations with both winning candidates on their priorities and plans. You'll find these interviews in the inside pages.

Republic Day was celebrated across Powai and Chandivali with great pride and enthusiasm. From schools to housing societies, the patriotic spirit was on full display, and we bring you a sneak preview of these celebrations inside.

This month's recipe page travels across India through the many avatars of pani puri—different names, ingredients, and flavours, yet equally irresistible. Our nutrition page focuses on iron deficiency in women, highlighting an often-overlooked health concern. The astrology page offers insights into what the stars have in store for you.

As always, My Powai is your platform. If you notice any irregularities or issues in and around our neighbourhood, do write to us. Together, let's keep Powai and Chandivali informed, engaged, and moving forward.

Happy reading, and enjoy the month..

Warm regards,
Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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If you see or experience any act of injustice in our locality please report to us: mypowai@yahoo.in

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Metro Rail may enter Powai this Diwali



D.P.K. Udas

The Metro Rail line from Swami Samarth Nagar to Vikhroli passes through Powai, with stations planned at IIT, Powai Lake and Rumbaugh.

Metro work began in 2017, and since then there has been nothing but "tarikh pe tarikh" when it comes to the date of completion. The reasons for delay are many—re-tendering, removal of encroachments, traffic congestion on busy roads, among others.

As per the last estimated timeline, the project is now expected to be completed by December 2027—ten long years after it first began.

This has naturally led to public outcry. If 99% of the flyover pier-cap work is already complete, why is there still such a delay?

One major reason cited is the non-readiness of the Metro Yard at Kanjur Marg due to land acquisition issues.

What is difficult to understand is how crores of rupees were spent on pillars and slabs without firming up the endpoint. It is like allowing a flight to take off towards a destination and then beginning land acquisition to construct the runway. Similar issues were seen earlier at Aarey and Gaimukh.

Now, MMRDA has decided not to wait for land acquisition at Kanjur Marg to build the depot and then start Metro Line 6. Instead, they have chosen to park Metro bogies on the elevated track beyond Vikhroli station. The pit lines will be used for maintenance of the bogies.

An early start of Metro Line 6 will be a huge relief for Powai residents. At present, many people drive up to Aarey, park their vehicles there, and then take Metro Line 3 to South Mumbai. With Line 6 operational, they can board the Metro directly from Powai.



Metro Line 6 also intersects with several other Metro lines:
A) Gandhinagar – Line 4 (Wadala–Thane)
B) Aarey Depot – Line 3 (Aarey–Cuffe Parade)
C) JVLR Station – Line 7 (Andheri–Dahisar)
D) Adarsh Nagar – Line 2A (Dahisar–DN Nagar)

This will give Powai residents connectivity to multiple corners of Mumbai.

All of us remember the massive tree cutting at Aarey for the Metro depot. Public sentiment was ignored, leading to what many now call #AareyKaShraap. Ironically, the solution of parking rakes on elevated tracks was already known then. In Kuala Lumpur, Metro rakes are parked on stations when services are not operational. Even our suburban railways follow a similar practice.

At that time, we had written to MMRDA suggesting that the loading platform used for placing rakes/bogies onto Metro tracks could be extended further at elevation, eliminating the need to cut trees below. Unfortunately, this suggestion was not accepted, and trees were cut mercilessly.

Now, as residents, the option before us is to compensate as much as possible—by planting more trees, by taking up with the BMC the idea of hanging flowering plants on streetlights, and by creating vertical gardens on Metro pillars.

There are court directives mandating the replantation of trees that were cut, along with additional plantation. MMRDA should publish a transparent status report on compliance with these directives.

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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A new chapter begins: Powai and Chandivali welcome their winning corporators



Name: Shri Chandan Sharma

Political Party:
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)

Ward No:
Ward 122 – Powai

Winning margin:
With 55 percent of the votes, it is a clear and decisive mandate, received with humility and gratitude from the people of Powai.

Your first civic fix?
Starting with the basics that touch daily life — smoother roads, free-flowing drains, cleaner surroundings, brighter streets, and a system that listens and responds quickly when residents call for help. This is where change must begin, and this is where my focus will be.

When will residents feel the change?
From day one, you will see action. Some changes will be visible almost immediately, while deeper, lasting improvements will roll out steadily — planned carefully and carried out with complete transparency.

Best way for citizens to reach you?
Through regular ward meetings, fixed office hours, social media, and direct interaction, my door will always remain open to the residents of Ward 122.

Tough calls or popular choices — what comes first?
What truly matters is Powai's long-term development. I will take the tough decisions today firmly and fairly to secure a stronger, better tomorrow for our community.

At the end of five years, what will make you proud?
If every resident of Ward 122 feels heard and respected, and can see their neighbourhood cleaner, safer, and better governed, then we will know we are moving in the right direction together.

One word that should define Ward 122?
Progress



Name: Dr. Sarita Mhaske

Political Party: Shiv Sena(UBT)

Ward No: 157

Winning Margin:
Won with 14,749 votes, with a margin of 1,800 votes

Your first civic fix?
Improving basic safety and cleanliness—better street lighting, CCTV cameras in sensitive areas, and immediate action on garbage, mosquitoes, and illegal activities affecting residents' daily life.

When will residents feel the change?
Residents will start seeing visible changes within the first 3–6 months, especially in safety, cleanliness, and responsiveness to complaints.

Best way for citizens to reach you?
Through regular ward meetings, WhatsApp helpline, and direct appointments. My doors will always be open for residents.

Tough calls or popular choices — what comes first?
Tough but right decisions always come first, because real development needs courage and honesty—not shortcuts.

At the end of five years, what will make you proud?
If Ward 157 becomes safer, cleaner, healthier, and people feel heard and respected—that will be my biggest achievement.

Powai and Chandivali have welcomed their new corporators with renewed hope and optimism. With clear public expectations, residents now look forward to time-bound action on long-pending civic issues that affect everyday life. Roads, cleanliness, drainage and basic services remain key priorities. My Powai wishes the newly elected corporators the very best and hopes they lead with accountability, accessibility and a genuine commitment to improving the quality of life for all.

When DIY Investing Grows Bigger Than You

(DIY = Do-It-Yourself Money Management)

Many financially successful families begin their journey with DIY investing—managing their own money, choosing products, tracking markets, and making decisions independently. In the early years, this works well. Goals are limited, time is abundant, and learning feels exciting.

But life doesn't remain simple.

Careers peak, incomes rise, investments multiply, and responsibilities grow. Real estate, mutual funds, insurance, retirement, children's education, tax planning—everything exists, but often in silos. At this stage, DIY doesn't fail because returns are poor. It feels exhausting because there's no single view of your financial life.

This is the silent shift many families experience.

Not from wealth creation—but from wealth coordination.

Consider Ravi, a 47-year-old senior professional. He earned well, invested regularly, owned a home, and tracked his portfolio diligently. On paper, everything looked right. Yet he felt uneasy. His investments were spread across platforms, decisions were made at different stages of life, and he wasn't sure how all of this would support his family ten or fifteen years later.

Ravi wasn't worried about returns.

He was worried about direction.

When his finances were reviewed holistically, nothing dramatic changed overnight. What changed was clarity. His investments were aligned to clear goals, risks were understood, cash flows were mapped, and tax planning became proactive. For the first time, Ravi knew why he was invested—not just where.

DIY investing focuses on products.

Planning focuses on purpose.

When markets fluctuate, uncertainty creeps in—not because money is lacking, but because clarity is. Families begin to ask deeper questions:

Will this support my lifestyle long-term?
Am I taking risks unknowingly?
Is my money working together—or just sitting in different places?

Signs you've outgrown DIY investing

- You track returns, but not future income
- Tax planning feels reactive
- Investments were made at different stages, without alignment
- Market swings disturb peace of mind
- You're financially successful, but not financially organised

At Oaktree, we work with families who have reached this inflection point. Our role is to bring structure, clarity, and calm—aligning investments with life goals, income needs, and long-term security.

Because financial maturity is not about doing everything yourself.

- Uma Kumaravelan
Certified Financial Planner
www.oaktree.in



Panch Smruti celebrates 77th Republic Day with patriotic fervour and community spirit



Panch Smruti celebrated the 77th Republic Day of India with great enthusiasm, unity, and patriotic pride. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from residents across all age groups, reflecting the vibrant and inclusive spirit of the society.

The celebrations commenced with the unfurling of the Indian National Flag, following which residents stood together to sing the National Anthem with pride. This was followed by the rendition of national song, marking the 150th anniversary of Vande Mataram, penned by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, paying tribute to India's rich cultural and freedom heritage.

Adding to the excitement of the day was a T5 Cricket Tournament, which saw active participation from residents of all ages. Four teams — Thunder Strikers, Power Hitters, Night Warriors, and Fire Blazers — competed in a series of spirited and competitive matches. The tournament culminated in a thrilling, nail-biting final that kept spectators on the edge of their seats.

Residents from across the building and the larger complex gathered in large numbers to cheer for their teams, creating an electrifying and festive atmosphere. The sporting spirit and camaraderie were evident throughout the event.

Post the final match, medals were distributed to the winning team and runners-up, along with appreciation for all participating teams, reinforcing the spirit of sportsmanship and friendly competition.

The celebration concluded with a community lunch, providing residents an opportunity to bond and celebrate together. The Republic Day celebration at Panch Smruti stood as a fine example of unity, patriotism, and community harmony, leaving behind cherished memories for all who attended.



Brentwood, Hiranandani Gardens



Lilium - Lantana, Nahar



Blue Haven, Raheja Vihar



JalVayu, Sector B



Symphony, Chandivali



Kanakia Silicon Valley, Powai



Orchid Enclave, Nahar



Powai Kerala Samajam



MHADA Bldg No.: 22 - 23



Castlerock, Hiranandani Gardens



Sovereign, Hiranandani Gardens



Synchronicity

Powai Metro's golden jubilee pilgrimage

Powai Metro 2025 proudly participated in the 50th Giants Convention held in Mathura, marking the Golden Jubilee celebrations. After completing the registration formalities, members contributed towards the travel expenses from Mumbai to Mathura, Uttar Pradesh. A dedicated WhatsApp group was created to share all travel-related information, schedules and arrangements, including the plan to assemble at Bombay Central, from where our train was scheduled to depart.

We reached Bombay Central well in time. With the help of a porter, our luggage—woollens neatly packed and food items thoughtfully arranged for everyone—was loaded. The train departed punctually. Soon, tea and snacks were served, followed by orders being taken for dinner and breakfast. While the stations en route were relatively quiet, the atmosphere changed dramatically as we entered Mathura, where the streets were bustling with people.

We checked into a comfortable hotel where rooms were allotted efficiently. Our luggage was labelled and delivered to the respective rooms. After refreshing ourselves, we enjoyed a sumptuous breakfast. Soon after, we set out in rickshaws, the most suitable local transport given Mathura's narrow gullies and lanes.

Our first visit was to Vrindavan, the sacred land where Lord Krishna is believed to have played with the gopis. The town is dotted with numerous temples dedicated to Lord Krishna. At the first temple, a long pathway led us to darshan, surrounded by devotees and tourists chanting "Radhe Radhe" and "Kunj Bihari." We then visited another temple where melodious bhajans were being sung and hot prasad was distributed. The final visit of the day was to the Yamuna Ghat, where the evening aarti was conducted on a grand scale. We returned to the hotel by rickshaw in the bitter cold, had dinner, and retired for the night.

The second day began with a quick freshening up after the previous day's strenuous schedule. We hurried to the lobby to board the waiting bus. As informed by the tour organiser, breakfast was arranged at the Golden Jubilee venue, offering a delightful mix of North and South Indian dishes.

We then proceeded to visit an array of Lord Krishna temples, travelling by e-autos—modified motorbikes used locally. At one of the temples, the priest asked for money for each ritual, even offering online payment options. Girls were available to paint faces like Goddess Radha, adding colour and charm to the experience. Everywhere, the air resonated with chants of "Radhe Radhe." The e-rickshaws ferried us from one temple to another.

We stopped for a sumptuous lunch at a North Indian restaurant. Later, we proceeded for another temple visit via a cable car. As the temple opened only at a fixed time, we waited for nearly an hour. The cable car queue was systematic, though the temple entrance itself was steep and crowded. After completing the darshan, we rested briefly and returned by cable car to where our auto-rickshaws were waiting. From there, we reached the spot where our bus was parked and returned to the venue—tired yet refreshed.

The evening was lively, with dinner accompanied by foot-tapping music that had everyone dancing. We retired for the night happy and relaxed, amused by the monkeys that had played pranks on visitors at several temples during the day.

The third day began at a more relaxed pace after the hectic previous schedule. Following a light breakfast, we proceeded to the venue. Despite the bitter cold, the seating was arranged outdoors under a covered canopy. The conference commenced with the compere welcoming the gathering, followed by addresses from the dignitaries, including Shaina NC, World Chairman and daughter of late politician Nana Chudasama.



A distinguished speaker from London spoke about the concept of gunas—Devgun, Manushya gun and Rakshas gun. She explained that Devgun signifies selfless giving, Manushya gun represents give-and-take, and Rakshas gun, while not inherently bad, can harm relationships if unchecked. She also highlighted the five elements—earth, air, water, fire and space—emphasising the importance of nurturing nature. She urged everyone to care for plants and even use leftover water to nourish them, reinforcing the need to respect all values of life.

All dignitaries praised the audience for travelling from far and wide to attend the 50th convention and highlighted Mathura's significance as the land of Lord Krishna. After lunch, the award ceremony was held. Some members later visited Gokul, where Lord Krishna is worshipped in his child form. The priest narrated the story of how baby Krishna was saved from his uncle Kansa and raised by Nandlal and Yashoda. Members were given the opportunity to gently rock the cradle of the child Krishna, with Balram and Yashoda present in the sanctum. The day concluded with members returning to the hotel for rest.

On the fourth day, after breakfast, we visited the Char Dham complex—a vast, well-secured area. The dhams included Shiv Dham, Radha Krishna Dham, Shani Dham and Vaishno Devi Dham, the last situated at a height and accessed through a cave-like pathway that felt remarkably realistic. At the centre of the complex stood a rotating statue of Lord Shiva. Facilities were well organised, with cloth bags provided for footwear and smooth, clean pathways throughout.

After completing the visit, we returned to the hotel to pack our bags and then boarded the bus to the railway station. Each participant received a kit containing meal coupons, identification neckbands for dignitaries and delegates, juice, milk beverages, snacks, a gift, a booklet on the dignitaries, and a writing pad with a pen. Upon reaching the station, we once again hired porters to manage the luggage, and boarded the train smoothly.

The return journey was comfortable, with snacks, tea and dinner served on board, followed by breakfast the next morning. We finally alighted at Bombay Central, delighted by the convention and deeply enriched by the divine experience of Mathura. Bidding goodbye to our co-passengers, we returned home—already dreaming of the next convention.

- Preeti oka

The courage to speak up: How emotional intelligence helps teens live healthier, happier lives



Debika Chaudhuri

Teenagers today are growing up in a world that often rewards being nice over being real. Social media, group chats, academic pressure, and fear of exclusion can quietly teach teens that silence is safer than honesty. But as emotional intelligence coach Harvey Deutschendorf reminds us in his book The Other Kind of Smart: Simple Ways to Boost Your Emotional Intelligence for Greater Personal Effectiveness and Success, emotional intelligence is not about avoiding discomfort, it's about having the courage to be open, honest, and authentic, even when it's hard.

Deutschendorf writes that emotional intelligence means being "real, open, and honest regarding our feelings," and that ignoring negative or destructive behavior does no one any favors. This insight is especially relevant for teens, whose emotional worlds are intense, social, and deeply shaped by peer dynamics. Developing the courage to speak up doesn't just improve relationships, it protects mental health, builds self-respect, and lays the foundation for a healthier adulthood.

Friend Groups and Group Chats

Many teens find themselves in group chats where jokes cross the line, gossip spreads, or someone is subtly mocked. When courage is avoided, teens often stay silent to avoid being excluded. On the surface, they appear easygoing, but internally they carry guilt, anxiety, and a growing fear of becoming the next target. Over time, this silence erodes self-respect and creates emotional insecurity.

When courage is developed, even simple responses like, "That's not cool, let's drop this," or privately expressing discomfort can change everything. Speaking up aligns teens with their values, reduces anxiety, and helps them form friendships rooted in respect rather than fear. Courage, in this way, creates emotional safety.

Peer Pressure and Risky Behavior

Peer pressure remains a powerful force, whether it involves vaping, drinking, cheating, or sharing inappropriate content. When teens go along with behavior they're uncomfortable with, they often experience shame, regret, and anxiety afterward. Silence becomes a form of self-betrayal.

By contrast, teens who can say, "That's not my thing," or "I'm not into that," build a stronger sense of self. Courage strengthens identity, reduces stress, and earns respect from the right people. As Deutschendorf suggests, honesty, handled with sensitivity, supports healthier outcomes for everyone involved.

Romantic Relationships and Boundaries

Teen relationships can blur boundaries, especially when constant texting, password sharing, jealousy, or emotional control is normalized. When teens stay quiet to keep a relationship, they often lose personal space and begin to confuse pressure with affection.



Courage allows teens to say, "I'm not comfortable with that," or "I need space." These honest expressions foster healthier relationships, clearer boundaries, and stronger self-worth. Emotional intelligence teaches teens that real connection does not require self-erasure.

School Pressure and Mental Health

Many teens struggle silently with anxiety, depression, or burnout while telling adults, "I'm fine." Fear of disappointing parents or teachers often keeps them from asking for help. The result can be worsening mental health, sleep problems, and emotional isolation.

When teens find the courage to say, "I'm overwhelmed," or "I need help," they open the door to early support, accommodations, and relief. As Deutschendorf's work emphasizes, courage here is not rebellion, it is self-preservation.

Bullying, Online and Offline

Whether experiencing bullying or witnessing it, teens often stay silent to protect themselves. Laughing along or scrolling past may feel safer in the moment, but it creates internal fear, moral distress, and long-term emotional scars. Courage can take many forms: reporting behavior, supporting a victim privately, or refusing to participate. Even quiet acts of honesty build moral confidence, reduce trauma, and contribute to safer environments. Emotional intelligence values action guided by empathy, not avoidance.

Identity, Authenticity, and Self-Expression

To fit in, many teens hide their opinions, interests, beliefs, or identities. While this may help them survive socially, it often leads to chronic insecurity and emotional numbness.

When teens express themselves honestly, even in small ways, they develop a stronger sense of self, greater confidence, and healthier friendships. Courage allows teens to be real instead of performative, which is essential for long-term emotional well-being.

What Harvey Deutschendorf Is Teaching Teens

At its core, The Other Kind of Smart teaches that emotional intelligence is not about being liked, it's about being true without being harmful. For teenagers, developing courage:

- reduces anxiety
- strengthens identity
- builds emotional resilience
- leads to healthier relationships

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

Courage on call: The guardians of Powai



Chaarvi Athawale

It was a bright morning on 11th January when a call came through to the Vikhroli Fire Brigade. At an RMC plant in Powai, a dog had fallen into an uncovered 15-foot-deep sewage manhole. The animal's frantic movements could be heard, but it remained invisible from the surface. "We could hear it whimpering," recalled one worker at the site. "It was terrifying, but we didn't know how to reach it."

Within minutes, a fire engine rolled in. A handful of residents and workers had gathered, scattered across the edges of the pit. "When we arrived, the pit was very narrow and dark," said Station Officer Vishnu Ahwad. "We had to be precise and careful; one wrong step could have put both the animal and the firefighter at risk."

A firefighter, harnessed and equipped with an oxygen mask, was lowered into the shaft. Minutes passed in tense silence before he reached the bottom, secured the dog, and signalled for the lift back up. Cheers went up from the crowd as the dog was safely placed on solid ground.



Just a week later, on the 15th, the same hole claimed another victim. The call came in the dead of night. Without hesitation, another firefighter descended into the shaft, bringing the second animal to safety. Both operations were completed without injury, a testament to the brigade's preparedness and coordination.

While Powai may see firefighters mainly battling blazes, their responsibilities extend far beyond. The team responds to building collapses, road accidents, medical emergencies, and animal rescues: dogs trapped in drains, birds tangled in wires, injured eagles stranded on rooftops. "We treat every life with the same urgency," said Ahwad. "It does not matter if it's human or animal. If someone or something is in danger, we respond."



Confined-space rescues are among the most challenging operations. Low oxygen, poor visibility, and unstable footing make them inherently risky. Yet the team relies on training, coordination, and strict safety protocols to minimize hazards. The repeated incidents at the RMC construction site also highlight a larger issue: construction safety in Powai. Open pits and uncovered shafts remain dangerous for workers, residents, and animals alike. "We hope these rescues serve as a reminder," Ahwad added. "Sites in Powai must follow safety protocols, not just for workers, but for everyone in the area."

Beyond emergency response, the brigade shapes how Powai navigates risk. Their readiness informs construction practices, community events, and even everyday routines. Leadership and teamwork are central to the brigade's effectiveness. Every operation is carefully coordinated, and each member understands their role. "Communication is key," Ahwad noted. "Everyone knows what to do, so when situations are unpredictable, we act decisively and safely."

The sewage manholes may be covered tomorrow, and Powai will carry on, but the work of the Vikhroli Fire Brigade leaves a lasting mark. Every rescue, every descent, every carefully planned operation is a reminder that the city is watched over by people who act without hesitation. For Powai, they are more than firefighters, they are truly guardians of safety, trust, and vigilance.

Their presence is quiet but undeniable, and Powai salutes a team whose courage, precision, and dedication keep life moving safely, day and night. To Officer Vishnu Ahwad and his team, a heartfelt thank you — for every life saved, every risk taken, and every hour spent ensuring that Powai remains a safer place for all who call it home.

Fatigue during sports: Is it poor fitness or poor nutrition?

Feeling tired early during a workout or game is a common experience for athletes at all levels. Many people immediately assume it means they are out of shape, but fatigue is not always a fitness problem. In many cases, it is closely linked to nutrition habits, hydration, and recovery routines. Understanding the difference can help athletes train smarter and perform better.

When Fatigue Is Related to Fitness

Conditioning-related fatigue usually appears when an athlete is still building endurance or strength. This type of fatigue tends to show up consistently during intense efforts such as sprinting, long runs, or extended games. Muscles may feel heavy, breathing may become difficult, and heart rate stays elevated for longer than expected.

If endurance improves steadily over weeks of training and fatigue sets in later during workouts, fitness is likely the main factor. This kind of tiredness is a normal part of athletic development and improves with structured training, rest days, and gradual increases in workload.

When fatigue is related to nutrition

Nutrition-related fatigue often feels different. Athletes may feel tired unusually early, lightheaded, unfocused, or weak even during sessions that are normally manageable. This type of fatigue can fluctuate day to day and may not improve despite consistent training.

Common nutrition-related causes include low carbohydrate intake, dehydration, inadequate protein, iron deficiency, or poor recovery meals. Carbohydrates are the body's primary fuel during exercise, and not eating enough can lead to early energy crashes. Dehydration can reduce blood volume and oxygen delivery, making physical activity feel harder than it should. In some athletes, especially those with heavy training schedules, low iron levels can also contribute to persistent fatigue.

Signs of underfueling

Athletes who are not eating enough to support their activity level may notice frequent exhaustion, slow recovery between sessions, irritability, trouble concentrating, or declining performance. Feeling hungry shortly after workouts or struggling to complete warm-ups can also be warning signs.

Underfueling does not always mean skipping meals. It can also mean poor timing, such as training hard after a long gap without food or failing to eat enough carbohydrates around practices.

Improving energy levels through nutrition

Simple nutrition strategies can make a significant difference. Eating a balanced meal or snack with carbohydrates and protein one to three hours before activity helps provide steady energy. Hydration throughout the day, not just during exercise, is also essential.

After workouts, a recovery meal with carbohydrates to replenish energy stores and protein to support muscle repair can reduce next-day fatigue. For athletes who train frequently, regular meals and snacks spaced evenly across the day are often more effective than large, infrequent meals.

Finding the balance

Fatigue is rarely caused by a single factor. Fitness, nutrition, sleep, and stress all interact to affect performance. Paying attention to patterns can help athletes identify the root cause. If fatigue improves with better fueling and hydration, nutrition was likely the issue. If it improves gradually with training progression, fitness was the limiting factor.

Learning to listen to the body and support it with both proper training and proper nutrition is key to long-term performance and enjoyment in sport.

- Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
Singapore International School (Mumbai)



Morning and evening in Powai



Girija Menon

Morning in Powai doesn't arrive in a hurry. It tiptoes in gentle and gracefully.

Walkers trace familiar paths, dogs tug at leashes, chai kettles begin to hiss, coffee aroma fills homes, newspapers land softly outside doors. Milk packets find their way into bags hung on door handles. Temple bells cut through the silence, not loud, just present. In December and January, the air carries a gentle chill, the kind that wakes you up slowly and kindly. A welcome dip in temperature in Mumbai.

Old trees host animated conversations. Birds chirp away like seasoned debaters, discussing how the day might unfold. Above them, the sun rises unhurriedly, brushing the sky with orange and gold. Clouds part, allowing warmth to descend and touch everything it finds. Humans, plants, insects. Life responds instinctively, because all life leans towards this powerful light.

Then the spell begins to lift.

Traffic seeps in. School buses, two wheelers, cyclists, transport vehicles. Corporate buses follow, claiming space. Autos weave through gaps like black and yellow insects on the move. Cars of every size assert their presence. Vegetable vendors arrive, carts transforming into stalls, many occupying the same corners they have for years. Now with the sun's warmth gathering heat the coconut vendor on his cycle awaits his regular customers as well as the new thirsty souls. This rhythm isn't unique to Powai, it belongs to cities everywhere. Only quieter, remote and probably the outskirts of the city hold on to stillness a little longer.

Evenings tells a different story.
Street lights come alive, food aromas float through the air, walkers and a few joggers share the pavements. Parents linger in gardens with children; pets are taken out by owners or by the now familiar sight of professional dog walkers. Laughter rings out from playgrounds and park play areas. The city exhales after a long workday, yet the streets grow increasingly restless. Walking turns into a quiet exercise in negotiation. Markets buzz louder, and during festive seasons, lights and colours vie for attention, especially that of wide-eyed children.

Restaurants overflow. Music echoes outside of glass doors onto roads. It feels like the world has stepped out at once.

Lively, yes. Energising, often. But overwhelming too, for those who live amidst it. The craving for quiet grows, though calm won't return until dawn. Until then, movement only multiplies.

That is Powai.
A daily exchange between pause and surge. Between hush and noise.

We often wonder if another suburb offers something gentler. Usually, it doesn't. Sometimes it's harsher. So perhaps the answer lies in acceptance. Staying rooted. Finding beauty in your own chaos. Riding the roller coaster, knowing stillness will return.

(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)



Emotional Regulation

A key to all human flourishing



Palak Sardana

"Anyone can be angry- that is easy. But to be angry with the right person, to the right degree, at the right time, for the right purpose, and in the right way- that is not easy". ~Aristotle

Emotions are primal and rooted in the primitive part of our brain. Even before humans developed language or abstract reasoning, emotions guided survival. Fear prepared the body to flee, anger to fight, affection to bond, and sadness to withdraw and conserve energy.

These emotional responses have refined over millions of years & continue to be hard-wired survival programs in our brains even today. Though the emotional demands of the modern life have changed, our primitive brain programs haven't. Our biology has not caught up with the complexity of the contemporary social environments and hence there exists a huge gap in our emotional reactions and the demands presented by the civil societies today.

During a recent visit to Delhi and the NCR, I witnessed a spontaneous episode of road rage in which a minor argument escalated into a physical altercation. I also learned of a deeply disturbing incident involving a family friend visiting from abroad. After a brief and unintentional contact between vehicles on a highway, the situation rapidly turned hostile. A group of individuals chose to "settle" the matter through intimidation and violence—smashing the windshield of my friend's car and threatening him and his family, including young children—leaving them severely traumatized.

Such incidents are stark examples of what neuroscientists describe as an amygdala hijack, where the emotional brain temporarily overrides rational thought. In these moments, the body is flooded with stress hormones, narrowing perception and suppressing the prefrontal cortex—the seat of reasoning, judgment, and impulse control. Actions are driven by raw emotion rather than conscious choice, often unfolding in seconds but carrying consequences that last far longer. What is enacted impulsively in anger almost always has personal, legal, and emotional costs for all involved.

Every day news is rife with such reports of disintegration of civility. Law enforcement authorities often bear the heat of public back-lash when such crimes take place. But in democratic set-ups, it is the civil society that must weave its fabric in a way where besides the knowledge of rules and regulations prescribed by law, there is also equal emphasis on promoting the art & science of emotional regulation. Squarely blaming the law enforcement agencies is like over-looking the root cause of disease and blaming the physician for its occurrence.

Most crimes are committed in a fit of uncontrolled and unchecked rage. There is substantial data that shows a worldwide trend for the present generation of children to be more troubled emotionally than the previous; lonelier and more depressed, more angry and unruly, more nervous and prone to worry and more impulsive and aggressive.



It is important to understand that emotions are not to be suppressed or discounted as they are not irrational intrusions but essential guides for survival, decision-making, and social coherence. Ignoring emotions is akin to ignoring sensory data. However, obeying emotions blindly is equally problematic. Recognizing emotions accurately, understanding their signals & choosing how to act upon them needs to be mastered to have a decent amount of control over the quality of our lives.

Huge expenditures are incurred on refining and updating educational curriculums and programs to better the career prospects of students. But unfortunately, addressal of emotions and their regulation hasn't found place in formal education system yet. Emotional education of children cannot be left to chance. A structured curriculum that inculcates essential human competencies like self-awareness, self-control, empathy and the art of listening, conflict resolution and cooperation, is much needed.

Emotional coaching begins with acknowledging emotions in self and others, naming them precisely & guiding their appropriate expression. Creating safe spaces where mistakes are acknowledged and accepted as a process of growth instead of condemnation and where emotions are not discounted or shamed is extremely important.

Pausing & absorbing before responding, withdrawal from the situation, slowing down breathing & relaxing a muscle group are some practical & tactical tools one can practice and master.

Emotional regulation not only helps in efficient navigation of worldly affairs, but it also impacts mental health positively. It prevents emotional overwhelm, reduces chronic stress, improves relationships, strengthens self-worth, and cultivates resilience. It makes room for emotions but never lets them dominate decisioning and action.

Emotional regulation also sets the preparatory ground for spiritual awakening. It reduces impulsiveness & reactivity, weakens habitual emotional patterns (saṁskāras), develops equanimity under stress & stops the mind from being dragged outward by every stimulus, hence creating a perfect internal environment for meditation.

Adopt the mantra of feeling fully, pausing wisely, reflecting deeply, acting mindfully & repairing quickly. You surely won't regret it!

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Women, iron deficiency and fatigue: a silent epidemic



Nisha Singh

Feeling tired has become so normal that many women don't even question it anymore. Long days, poor sleep, work pressure, family responsibilities—fatigue is often waved off as part of life. But when exhaustion becomes constant, when simple tasks feel heavy, when rest doesn't quite restore energy, it's worth pausing. Very often, the reason is quietly sitting in the background - Iron Deficiency.

This isn't a rare problem or a niche medical issue. It affects women across age groups—students, working professionals, new mothers, and those nearing menopause. And yet, it remains under-recognised, under-treated, and frequently dismissed.

Iron plays an important role in carrying oxygen through the blood. When iron levels drop, the body struggles to deliver oxygen efficiently, and fatigue is often the first signal.

Women are especially vulnerable for several reasons:
- **Monthly blood loss:** Regular menstrual cycles mean regular iron loss. Heavy or prolonged periods increase this risk significantly.
- **Increased needs during certain life stages:** Adolescence, pregnancy, breast-feeding, and recovery after childbirth all demand higher iron intake.
- **Dietary gaps:** Many women eat less overall, skip meals, or prioritise feeding others first. Iron-rich foods are often limited, especially when diets are restrictive or repetitive.
- **Poor absorption:** Even when iron intake looks adequate on paper, absorption may be low due to digestive issues, frequent antacid use, or low intake of vitamin C.
- **Frequent dieting:** Chronic dieting, extreme calorie restriction, or cutting out food groups can quietly drain iron stores over time.

What makes iron deficiency tricky is that it builds slowly. The body adapts. Symptoms creep in quietly, and by the time they're obvious, iron stores are often quite low.
Iron deficiency doesn't always show up as dramatic weakness. It's usually subtle and spread out across daily life.
Common signs include: • Constant tiredness, even after a full night's sleep • Breathlessness during mild activity • Frequent headaches or light-headedness • Pale skin or dark circles that don't improve • Hair thinning or increased hair fall • Brittle nails or nail ridges • Feeling cold more often than others • Poor concentration and brain fog • Increased irritability or low mood • Restless legs or muscle discomfort

Many women chalk these up to stress, ageing, hormones, or poor sleep. And while those factors can contribute, iron deficiency often sits underneath, quietly amplifying everything else.

Iron doesn't only come from supplements. In fact, long-term correction works best when food habits improve alongside medical treatment.
Here's how to support iron intake using everyday foods:
1. Include iron-rich foods regularly
Plant-based sources include:
• Dark leafy greens • Lentils, beans, and chickpeas • Sesame seeds, pumpkin seeds • Dried fruits like raisins and dates • Whole grains and fortified cereals Animal-based sources (if included): • Eggs • Red meat in moderate amounts • Liver (occasionally)

Consistency matters more than quantity. Small daily additions work better than occasional large servings.



2. **Pair iron with vitamin C**
Vitamin C improves iron absorption. Add:
• Citrus fruits • Tomatoes • Bell peppers • A squeeze of lemon on meals
This simple pairing can significantly improve how much iron your body actually uses.

3. **Watch timing with tea and coffee**
Tea and coffee reduce iron absorption. Avoid having them immediately before or after meals. A gap of one to two hours helps.

4. **Use cast iron cookware**
Cooking certain foods in cast iron pans can help increase iron content, especially with acidic foods. These are supportive steps, not quick fixes—but over time, they make a meaningful difference.
Iron deficiency doesn't exist in isolation. Daily habits influence how quickly and effectively levels recover.
Eat regular meals: Skipping meals worsens fatigue and disrupts nutrient intake. Even small, balanced meals help maintain energy and absorption.
Address heavy periods: Excessive blood loss is a major cause of low iron. If periods are unusually heavy, painful, or prolonged, medical evaluation is essential.
Manage digestive health: Constipation, bloating, acidity, or frequent stomach upset can interfere with nutrient absorption. Supporting gut health improves long-term results.

Don't ignore rest
When iron is low, the body is already under strain. Overtraining, extreme workouts, or constant pushing can delay recovery.

Be cautious with supplements
Iron supplements are often necessary, but they should be taken under guidance. Incorrect dosing can cause side effects or poor absorption.

A word of caution, Many women feel discouraged when they start iron supplements but don't feel better immediately. That's normal. Iron stores take time to rebuild. Fatigue often improves first, while hair and skin changes take longer. Consistency is key. Also, iron deficiency may coexist with other issues—low vitamin B12, thyroid imbalance, or chronic stress. Treating iron alone helps, but full recovery often requires a broader view.

While women are more affected, iron deficiency impacts everyone. Men and older adults can experience it too, often due to poor diet, absorption issues, or chronic conditions. Addressing iron deficiency in women benefits families, workplaces, and communities. Energy levels improve. Focus returns. Quality of life changes in small but powerful ways.

Living with constant fatigue slowly shrinks life. Social plans feel tiring. Exercise feels overwhelming. Even joy starts to feel like effort. Iron deficiency is not about weakness or poor self-care. It's about biology, life stages, and overlooked needs.The good news? Once identified, it's manageable. With the right food choices, lifestyle adjustments, and medical support where needed, energy can return—steadily and sustainably.

Feeling tired all the time isn't something you have to accept. Sometimes, it's simply your body asking for what it has been missing for far too long.

And listening to that signal can change everything.

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

The many names of taste



Sherry Bhatnagar

There are few things in India that unite strangers instantly. A cricket match crackling through a radio. The smell of rain on sun-warmed earth. And a plate of crisp puris waiting to be filled—one by one—at a street-side cart.

Call it **golgappa, pani puri, puchka, gupchup, or fulki.** The name changes every few hundred kilometres, but the feeling is unmistakably Indian.

This humble snack is not just food; it is instinct. A shared cultural reflex. The moment the vendor cracks open a puri with a practiced thumb, spoons in spiced potato, peas or chana, and dips it into flavoured water, time slows. Conversations pause. Eyes sharpen. Anticipation peaks. That first bite—crunch, burst, heat—needs no translation.

In North India, golgappas arrive bold and unapologetic. Larger puris, assertive flavours, waters that lean fiery—sometimes sharp with hing, sometimes bright with mint and coriander. Sweetness is optional; spice is non-negotiable.

Travel west to Maharashtra and Gujarat and the same snack transforms into pani puri—lighter, crisper, more playful. Here, sweet and spicy waters find harmony, and thin puris shatter delicately on the tongue.

In Kolkata, puchka tells its own story. Less sweet, more intense. Spicier fillings, deeper tamarind, sharper water. It mirrors the city itself—layered, opinionated, proudly distinct.

Further east, Odisha's gupchup delivers a garlicky punch, while Bihar and Jharkhand's phuchka celebrates heat and rustic honesty. Madhya Pradesh's fulki—smaller, tangier—quietly proves that satisfaction has nothing to do with size.

What makes this snack extraordinary is not its ingredients; they are modest. It is its adaptability. Like India, it absorbs the character of every place it touches. It honours local palates, climates, and cravings. It refuses to be just one thing.

Golgappa is also deeply democratic. It asks for no occasion and no ceremony. It belongs equally to schoolchildren clutching pocket money, office-goers chasing nostalgia, families on evening walks, and travellers seeking a sense of place. It is eaten standing up, laughing, bargaining spice levels, trusting the vendor completely.

Perhaps that is why it endures. In a country of infinite diversity, it reminds us that unity does not demand uniformity. One puri at a time, it celebrates difference—crisply, joyfully, deliciously. One snack. Many identities. Infinite cravings. Let's be realistic. Let's grab a big packet of readymade puris and start our indulgence:

The soul of every golgappa begins with a humble, well-balanced filling:
- Boiled potatoes, lightly mashed
- Boiled white peas or black chana
- Finely chopped onions (optional, region-specific)
- Green chillies (to taste)
- Fresh coriander
- Salt & roasted cumin powder
- A hint of lemon juice or tamarind pulp

This filling acts as a neutral canvas—allowing the pani to define the personality. All you need to do is add all as per your choice and mix well.



Four Classic Varieties of Pani (Flavoured Water)

1. Teekha Pudina Pani (Green Pani) : (serves ~25–30 puris)
- Fresh mint leaves – 1 cup (packed)
- Fresh coriander – ½ cup
- Green chillies – 2–3
- Ginger – 1 inch
- Lemon juice – 2 tbsp
- Black salt – 1½ tsp
- Roasted cumin powder – 1 tsp
- Regular salt – ½ tsp
- Cold water – 3–4 cups

Method:
Grind mint, coriander, chillies, ginger with a little water to a smooth paste. Strain (optional). Add remaining ingredients and cold water. Chill well.
Where it's most used: Delhi, Haryana, Punjab, Western UP, Rajasthan
(North India's bold, spicy signature pani)

2. Khatta Meetha Imli Pani:
- Tamarind pulp – ½ cup
- Jaggery (grated) – ¼ cup
- Dates paste (optional but classic) – 2 tbsp
- Roasted cumin powder – 1 tsp
- Dry ginger powder – ½ tsp
- Red chilli powder – ¼ tsp
- Black salt – 1 tsp
- Cold water – 2½–3 cups

Method:
Mix tamarind pulp and jaggery till dissolved. Add spices and water. Strain for smoothness.
Where it's most used: Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, parts of MP
(Western India's love for balance and sweetness)

3. Hing Jeera Pani:
- Asafoetida (hing) – ¼ tsp
- Roasted cumin powder – 1½ tsp
- Black salt – 1 tsp
- Regular salt – ½ tsp
- Lemon juice – 1½ tbsp
- Crushed coriander seeds – ½ tsp
- Cold water – 3 cups

Method:
Dissolve hing in lemon juice first. Add all spices and water. Rest for 10 minutes before serving.
Where it's most used: Delhi, UP, Rajasthan, MP
(Old-school North Indian digestive style)

4. Lehsuni Pani (Garlic Pani)
- Garlic cloves – 6–8
- Green chillies – 2
- Fresh coriander – ¼ cup
- Lemon juice – 1½ tbsp
- Black salt – 1 tsp
- Salt – ½ tsp
- Cold water – 3 cups

Method:
Grind garlic, chillies, coriander to a paste. Mix with remaining ingredients and water. Let it rest 15 minutes for flavour release.
Where it's most used: Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Jharkhand, parts of MP
(Rustic, punchy, unapologetically spicy) I personally feel when this flavoured water hits my tastebuds- Green pani excites, Imli pani balances,Hing pani comforts and Lehsuni pani shocks (in a good way).

Same filling. Same puri.
Different pani—different personality.

(Sherry Bhatnagar is a passionate food storyteller with deep roots in Indian regional cuisine, the author writes where memory, migration, and the kitchen intersect. Having lived across cultures yet firmly anchored in Indian flavours, her work explores food not just as nourishment, but as identity, tradition, and lived experience—told with honesty, restraint, and quiet depth.)

February 2026



Richa Pathak

February slows the pace just enough to help you feel before you decide. This month teaches balance—between heart and mind, effort and surrender, desire and discipline.

Aries (Mar 21 – Apr 19)
This month asks you to slow your inner fire just a little. Not because you're weak, but because clarity arrives when you pause. Professionally, silent preparation will benefit you more than loud action. In relationships, gentler words will heal more than strong opinions. **Lucky Color:** Cherry Red **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Keep a small iron object near your work desk to ground excess Mars energy.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
February feels comforting for you, like coming back to yourself. You'll crave emotional security and financial order, and that's exactly what this month supports. Spend mindfully, love deeply, and trust that slow consistency is working in your favour. **Lucky Color:** Warm Beige **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Apply a drop of rose oil or fragrance on your wrists to strengthen Venus harmony.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
Your mind stays active, but February teaches you to choose meaningful conversations over constant chatter. A talk you've been avoiding may finally bring relief. Focus improves when you reduce distractions. **Lucky Color:** Mint Green **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Write important thoughts or worries in a green notebook to calm Mercury restlessness.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
Emotionally, this is a nurturing month for you. Old feelings surface not to disturb you, but to be understood and released. Family matters slowly find balance, and disciplined saving gives peace of mind. **Lucky Color:** Moon Grey **Lucky Day:** Sunday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of clean water near your bed on Mondays to soothe emotional energy.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
February softens your expression without dimming your light. You'll realise that quiet confidence attracts more appreciation than forceful presence. Creative efforts flourish when you stay authentic. **Lucky Color:** Honey Gold **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Light a ghee lamp near a mirror to strengthen self-worth and clarity.

Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
This month reminds you that everything doesn't need fixing. Some things need acceptance. Health, routine, and work improve naturally once you stop being harsh on yourself. Progress is already happening—trust it. **Lucky Color:** Pistachio Green **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Keep your work table clutter-free and place a clear glass bowl to calm the mind.



Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
Relationships gently test your balance this month. You'll understand where you've been giving too much or too little. Honest communication restores harmony, and financial planning brings reassurance. **Lucky Color:** Powder Pink **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Place a crystal or glass object in the southwest of your home to stabilise relationships.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
February asks you to loosen control and trust the process. Emotional honesty—especially with yourself—brings relief. Financial instincts sharpen, helping you make confident choices. **Lucky Color:** Deep Violet **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Burn a clove or cinnamon stick weekly to release emotional heaviness.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
Your optimism returns quietly, without chaos. Plans for growth, travel, or learning begin forming again, but this time with maturity. Small disciplined steps will take you far. **Lucky Color:** Sapphire Blue **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Keep a yellow notebook or cloth near your desk to activate Jupiter's guidance.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
February teaches you emotional maturity. Work remains steady, but relationships need warmth, not structure. Don't underestimate the power of rest—your strength multiplies when you pause. **Lucky Color:** Slate Grey **Lucky Day:** Saturday **Remedy:** Write one appreciation note for yourself every Saturday to soften self-pressure.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
Your birthday season brings fresh perspective. Ideas flow, people listen, and your originality feels welcomed. Just remember to rest—mental brilliance needs physical balance. **Lucky Color:** Aqua Blue **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of clean water near a window to enhance clarity and inspiration.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
As your solar cycle approaches, intuition heightens. You may sense answers before questions are asked. Creative or spiritual practices calm your heart. Stay mindful with money. **Lucky Color:** Sea Mist Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Apply sandalwood or rosewater on your wrists before sleep for emotional peace.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8452920640 & www.jyotishdham.com)